enterprises had failed, leaving their Indian investors in the lurch. Alluding to Tenali Raman's cat[21]—once bitten twice shy—he warned that indigenous investors were therefore quite wary and would require solid reassurance. More ominously, he suggested that VOC should explain the reworked figures, brainstorm the issues and even take the help and advice of Bombay-based personalities such as Mehta and Wacha—references apparently to the moderate Congress leaders Pherozeshah Mehta and Dinshaw Wacha; but what lessons VOC could learn from consulting them was not clearly spelt out. (Evidently, the interlocutor was a member of the moderate faction of Congress and was thus not favourably disposed to VOC's overt pro-Tilak leanings.) In a parting shot, Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar compared Indian businessmen unfavourably with their European counterparts, and generally derided Indians for lacking in character and enterprise.[22]

Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar signed off his warning with 'Vande Mataram'. While taking this as a sign of his bona fides, VOC could not possibly ignore this long missive hitting at the very root of his mission. Responding at length, he provided a point-by-point rebuttal, which appeared in two parts, in *Swadesamitran*.

To begin with, VOC said, Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar had gotten the figures wrong: the annual profits would be to the tune of Rs 10 lakh and not just Rs 5 lakh! To verify this estimate, VOC invited him to look at the statistics at the sea customs office. Moreover, once he set his eyes on the steamers, remarked VOC, Sadhu Ramasubbaiyar would have no quarrels about his estimates. After the costs were recouped—this would take only a year—the shipping company could function in perpetuity, at great profit. Regarding import–export, all the business was in the hands of Indian traders, and given that an overwhelming number of them had already subscribed to the Swadeshi company, the entire profits would accrue to them. Why would Swadeshi traders with ownership stakes in the company resort to BI steamers, he asked.

Regarding passage, VOC argued that only half of the passengers were plantation labourers. The rest were traders and others whose livelihood was based in Colombo. Even with respect to the labourers, the planters were